On issues of diplomacy and security, Netanyahu's fourth government effectively had no opposition. The Zionist Union was busy fighting amongst itself, consumed with one of its quadrennial leadership struggles; no less than nine challengers would line up to run against Herzog in the 2017 primary. Yair Lapid, the centrist talk show host-turned-politician who hoped to become the next prime minister, tried to position himself for a future election by moving to the right and avoiding any major criticism of Netanyahu on defense issues.

The only real criticism, ironically, came from the men who once executed Netanyahu's security policy. During his four terms in power, the prime minister has worked with twenty different defense ministers, army chiefs, and directors of the Shin Bet and the Mossad. Thirteen of them have publicly attacked his policies and leadership; of the seven who haven't, three are currently in office. (Lieberman himself is among the critics.)

Their role as the loyal opposition highlights the failure of the Israeli political system to debate the country's most serious issues. It has also turned the army and the security services into a political football—perhaps one of the most dangerous trends in recent years.

## *The melting pot*

The Israeli army, unsurprisingly, occupies an exalted place in society, and not only because the country has been almost constantly at war since it was founded. Israel's system of mandatory conscription makes it one of the few institutions that brings together young people from across ethnic, socioeconomic and religious lines. Secular middle-class kids from Tel Aviv meet religious teenagers from Jerusalem, poor soldiers from the Negev, and Druze boys from villages in the Galilee. New immigrants learn Hebrew. David Ben-Gurion, the first Israeli prime minister, referred to it as a "melting pot".

"The IDF must serve not only as a military training apparatus but also as a state school that imbues the youth entering its ranks with knowledge of the language, the country, Jewish history, the fundamentals of general education, neatness and order, and, most importantly, love of the homeland," he wrote in 1964.[4]

At the highest levels, though, the officer corps has historically been far less diverse. Its top ranks, especially in the elite combat units, were